

Overview: Visual Supports / Now-Next

Visual supports replace the uncertainty of "what's happening?" with concrete, visible information. Now-Next boards, checklists, cue cards, and visual timers reduce verbal load and provide an ongoing reference the pupil can check independently without asking. This dramatically reduces anxiety for pupils who struggle with transitions or unpredictability.

When to Use This Strategy

- Constantly asks "What are we doing now?" or "What's next?"
- Becomes anxious or distressed during transitions
- Waits for peers to move before doing anything
- Seems unable to start tasks independently
- Appears lost when verbal instructions end

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Create a Now-Next board

Make a simple A4 card with two sections: NOW on the left, NEXT on the right. Add Velcro strips for attaching activity cards, or simply use Post-it notes.

Tip: Don't wait for laminated perfection. Post-it notes on paper work immediately.

2 Make activity cards

Create small cards for common activities: Writing, Reading, Video, Discussion, Break, Pack up. Use words, pictures, or both depending on the pupil.

Tip: Start with 6-8 cards covering your typical lesson activities.

3 Position the visual where they can see it

Put the Now-Next on the pupil's desk, or at the front for whole-class use. The pupil must be able to see it without asking permission or moving.

Teacher says: "This is your Now-Next board. It always tells you what's happening."

4 Teach the pupil to use it

Don't assume they know. Explicitly teach them to check the visual before asking you. Practice: "Before you ask me what's next, check your board."

Teacher says: "Look at your Now-Next. Point to NOW. What are we doing?"

Tip: Build the habit through practice, not assumption.

5 Update BEFORE transitions

Before you change activities, update the board so the pupil can see what's coming. This is crucial. They see the change before it happens.

Teacher says: "I'm updating your NEXT card now. Watch—we're moving to reading after this."

6 Refer to it consistently

Build the habit by pointing to the visual regularly. "Check your Now-Next" becomes a familiar prompt that redirects without repeating instructions.

Teacher says: "Check your board. What's next? That's right—pack up time."

English Example: Extended writing with First-Then card

Year 8 pupil resists writing tasks. They want to skip to preferred activities. Working at KS2 level for extended writing.

Set up First-Then card

Teacher: Place First-Then card on desk. FIRST shows "Writing - 3 sentences". THEN shows the pupil's preferred activity (e.g., drawing).

Pupil: Sees the visual contract. Understands the deal.

Point to the contract

Teacher: Say: "Look at your card. First, writing. Just three sentences. Then, drawing. I'll set the timer."

Pupil: Looks at card. Sees both parts of the deal clearly.

Support the writing

Teacher: Provide sentence starters. Point to FIRST card as reminder. "Two more sentences, then it's THEN time."

Pupil: Writes sentences. Checks card for motivation.

Complete the contract

Teacher: Remove FIRST card. Say: "You did it. First is done. Now it's THEN time. You earned it."

Pupil: Sees the visual proof they completed the task. Moves to preferred activity.

Maths Example: Lesson schedule for anxious pupil

Year 7 pupil becomes anxious when they don't know how long things will last or what's coming. Working at age-appropriate level but needs predictability.

Display lesson schedule

Teacher: Write on whiteboard visible to all: 1. Starter 2. Teaching 3. Practice 4. Plenary 5. Pack up. Add approximate times if helpful.

Pupil: Sees entire lesson structure at a glance.

Start the lesson

Teacher: Say: "Here's what we're doing today. It's all on the board. I'll cross each one off when we finish it."

Pupil: Knows what to expect. Can see the whole journey.

Mark progress

Teacher: Cross off completed sections. Say: "Starter done. Watch me cross it off. What's next? Practice."

Pupil: Sees visual proof of progress. Knows position in the lesson.

Add a timer (optional)

Teacher: Display visual timer next to schedule. "Practice for 15 minutes. You can see the time on the timer."

Pupil: Can check both what they're doing and how long is left independently.

Science Example: Practical method with visual checklist

Year 7 practical with six steps. Pupil working at KS1 level struggles to hold method in memory.

Display method visually

Teacher: Write numbered steps on whiteboard with simple diagrams. Large, clear, visible from all desks.

Pupil: Can see all steps. Doesn't need to remember them.

Introduce the visual

Teacher: Say: "Today's practical has six steps. They're all on the board. We'll tick each one as we do it."

Pupil: Understands they can check the board instead of asking.

Track progress during practical

Teacher: Tick completed steps. Circle current step. "Step three done. We're on step four now. What's step four? Read it from the board."

Pupil: Reads step from board. Completes it. Checks for next step.

Celebrate completion

Teacher: Tick final step. "Look—all six steps ticked. You completed the whole practical by following the board."

Pupil: Sees visual proof of achievement. Six ticks.